

1353 Enslaved Swimmers and Divers in the Atlantic World

This study demonstrates that bondpeople's swimming activities touched their everyday lives in important ways. In an age when few westerners could swim, many slaves mastered the skill. Recreational swimming allowed field slaves to relax and cleanse themselves. When bondpeople competed in races or battled marine creatures, they exhibited their skills and won material rewards, which probably enhanced their prestige and self-esteem and increased the slave communities' sense of cohesion. Slaveholders probably had to treat enslaved swimmers and divers differently from most other skilled bondpeople. Owners could replace most slaves who possessed land-based proficiencies with other competent slaves without interrupting production much. They could not dismiss divers without causing significant work disruptions and even stoppages. Enslaved divers thus resembled the antebellum industrial slave laborers whom Charles B. Dew has described. Through years of apprenticeship, which could begin when they were boys, some industrial bondmen became highly skilled laborers who made themselves indispensable to iron making. For example, in 1847 the Tredegar Iron Works purchased thirty-two slaves and groomed them for over a decade, making them the elite of its fettered population. The time, attention, and money dedicated to their training suggests that replacements could not be readily obtained. Indeed, Dew argued that their positions were secure unless a catastrophe occurred that forced the liquidation of assets, such as the factory owner's death. Furthermore, industrial slaves seem to have had lifelong appointments that might be passed from father to son. Divers too probably began learning their skills when they were young boys. There is no evidence of diving positions passing from father to son. But enslaved divers would have needed to become proficient swimmers by an early age and to swim regularly to develop the lung capacity and composure required to work calmly and smoothly in strenuous conditions without panicking and using up their oxygen, a reaction that would lessen their efficiency and could cost them their lives. Thus, if slaveholders wanted to train slaves as divers, they probably identified young, proficient swimmers whom divers could tutor.⁶⁹ Consequently, as slave owners engaged in the continually negotiated relationship with their slaves that Ira Berlin has described, they doubtless had to concede some autonomy to their divers and to temper claims to absolute authority. In salvaging goods from sunken ships far out at sea or clearing debris from inland fisheries, slaveholders did not have the luxury of discharging a diver to exhibit their authority or to punish an infraction, and severe beatings could unfit divers for work. Slave owners wanted diving jobs completed quickly and successfully, and they could not easily replace divers. Furthermore, slaveholders may have realized that they were privileged to own slaves possessing such a rare and lucrative ability. Thus, slaves employed in salvage, fishery, and sometimes even pearl diving had leverage to exact privileges from their owners.⁷⁰

⁶⁹ Charles B. Dew, *Ironmaker to the Confederacy: Joseph R. Anderson and the Tredegar Iron Works* (New Haven, 1966), 27; Dew, *Bond of Iron*, 26, 171–219. Hardy, *Travels in the Interior of Mexico*, 231–60; Stedman, *Narrative of Five Year's Expedition Against the Revolted Negroes of Surinam*, 154. ⁷⁰ Ira Berlin, *Many Thousands Gone: The First Two Centuries of Slavery in North America* (Cambridge, Mass., 1998), 1–4. Virginia Bernhard stated that Bermudian bondpeople taught many white islanders to swim. Yet wreckers' tendency to have at least one enslaved diver suggests that those whites could not dive to great depths. Bernhard, *Slaves and Slaveholders in Bermuda*, 23–24, 107, 178.